

Storms could easily set off slides

L.A. prepares for debris flows in burn scars and elsewhere as a strong atmospheric river looms this week.

BY HANNAH FRY AND RONG-GONG LIN II

An atmospheric river forecasters say is likely to be the strongest in nearly a year is set to unleash rain across Southern California this week, heightening concerns of damaging debris flows in areas ravaged by wildfire.

Rain is forecast to arrive by Wednesday morning, but the bigger threat is expected Thursday with heavy precipitation and strong winds that could cause flooding, power outages and travel delays.

Los Angeles County public works crews have created additional capacity in debris basins and installed thousands of feet of concrete barriers ahead of the rain. Crews have also put out sandbags and compost filter socks — a type of berm — and other items in fire zones to filter debris and prevent it from flowing into storm drains and out into the ocean, said L.A. County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath.

Crews had begun putting these measures into place in the burn zones ahead of last week's rain, which was relatively light and caused only a few problems with rock-slides and mudflows on roads.

Horvath recommended that residents sign up for emergency alerts at ready.lacounty.gov, where they can also find information about sandbag distribution and other ways to prepare homes for the incoming rain.

"It's been a challenging 2025 and we just want to get to a place of feeling normal and that we're back to feeling like we can be at home," Horvath said. "But these advisements around potential emergency and preparedness, in particular, are to keep people safe. We don't want people to have emergency fatigue. We want them to be informed."

The storm is expected to drop between 1½ and 3 inches of rain across much of Los Angeles County with between 3 and 6 inches of precipitation expected along south-facing mountains and foothills. The storm will also unleash strong winds — up to 60 mph in some areas — on Thursday, said Ryan Kittell, a meteorologist with the National Weather Service in [See [Rain](#), A10]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times
SHARON BARLOW, an Altadena resident since 1970, pauses while clearing weeds from her property on Monterosa Drive as she prepares for runoff from this week's predicted rain in the aftermath of the Eaton fire.

Will Edison survive Eaton?

What the deadly, destructive fire could mean for the giant utility's bottom line and its investors if it is found liable

BY CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

As Los Angeles grapples with the fallout of last month's destructive wildfires, one question looms: What does it mean for Southern California Edison, the giant utility that has been accused of sparking a blaze?

The answer will hinge on whether state agencies determine Edison's equipment ignited the deadly Eaton fire that destroyed a huge swath of Altadena in the foothills north of Los Angeles. If the fire did start with Edison, and the company is found to have failed to take reasonable steps to prevent the blaze, it will be on the hook for billions of dollars in losses suffered by fire victims, insurance companies and others.

The economic hit to Edison, a fixture in California for well more than a century that has grown into a Wall Street behemoth, could be significant. But industry experts say the utility is [See [Edison](#), A7]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times
SOUTHERN California Edison workers attach lines to a telephone pole on Jan. 15 near a structure in Altadena destroyed by fire.

Spilling secrets of L.A.'s underworld

Witness in federal trial testifies he killed for the Aryan Brotherhood

BY MATTHEW ORMSETH

James Field tattooed stitches over his lips in a vow to never reveal the secrets of the Aryan Brotherhood.

He dreamed of one day joining the syndicate that ruled over the prison yards where he spent most of his

adult life. He robbed, extorted and killed for them, he testified, until the day he became convinced the men he idolized had turned on him.

Now Field is a protected witness for federal prosecutors seeking to convict three of the Aryan Brotherhood's reputed leaders.

"I'd been brainwashed for a long time about prison politics and how all this comes first," he testified last month in a Fresno courtroom. "This whole life — violence, drug use, this white supremacist stuff."

The Aryan Brotherhood was created in prison, but Field testified that its influ-

ence has seeped into the streets of Los Angeles County. In seedy motels, gambling parlors and crash pads from Lancaster to Long Beach, drug dealers and fraudsters rubbed shoulders with ex-cons such as Field, who said he was paroled in late 2021 with in- [See [Brotherhood](#), A5]

Cal Fire updates hazard severity maps

The revisions are expected to more than double the acreage that will be subject to stricter building codes.

BY NOAH HAGGERTY

The California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection began rolling out a long-awaited update to its fire hazard severity zones Monday, which is set to more than double the number of acres in local fire jurisdictions that must comply with stricter fire safety building codes.

Previously, the state mapped and applied fire safety regulations only to local areas with the highest possible fire hazards, deemed "very high." But in 2021, the state Legislature ordered Cal Fire to expand the mapping to include "high" hazard zones so the Legislature could apply fire safety building regulations to the new "high" zones as well.

The new maps are expected to expand the roughly 800,000 acres currently in local fire jurisdictions zoned as "very high" by an additional 247,000 acres. Some 1.16 million acres will be categorized into the new "high" zones, according to a press release from the governor's office.

Cal Fire will also release new "moderate" hazard zones, its lowest hazard classification, which is rarely referenced in fire safety regulations, but did not state how many acres it would encompass.

The agency hasn't released maps for these local areas — on city and county land where local fire departments, not Cal Fire, are responsible for responding to fires — since 2011.

Cal Fire initially planned to release the maps in January, but the Los Angeles firestorms halted the rollout. Cal Fire officials said many of the agency's mapping personnel, including scientists, were supporting the fire-fighting and recovery efforts and that they didn't want to burden communities already facing the daunting task of rebuilding.

However, after Gov. Gavin Newsom signed an executive order Thursday on fire safety that, in part, ordered Cal Fire to release the maps, the agency obliged. [See [Maps](#), A10]

Steel, aluminum tariffs unveiled

President Trump announces 25% import duties, including on Canadian and Mexican metals. **NATION, A4**

Trump expands '60 Minutes' suit

The president demands \$20 billion, adds a Texas lawmaker as a plaintiff in case over Harris interview. **BUSINESS, A6**

Weather

Low clouds clearing. L.A. Basin: 62/47. **B6**

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CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

STEEP DROP IN MONARCHS

The butterfly's Western population has reached a near-record low, a winter survey finds. The culprits include pesticides and fire. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Federal judge halts cuts to NIH grants after 22 states file lawsuit

California and other parties say capping funding for overhead would imperil vital medical research.

BY JAWEED KALEEM

A federal judge in Massachusetts on Monday blocked the Trump administration from making billions of dollars in funding cuts to the National Institutes of Health hours after California and 21 other Democratic-

run states sued, saying the action would hurt Americans who benefit from life-saving medical discoveries regarding cancer, diabetes and other major diseases.

In granting a temporary restraining order, U.S. District Judge Angel Kelley suggested that she agreed, for the time being, with arguments in the lawsuit saying the drastic cuts would cause irreparable harm to medical research at the University of California, California State University and other institutions.

The states, backed by university presidents, al-

leged in the suit that a \$4-billion loss of funding would "result in layoffs, suspension of clinical trials, disruption of ongoing research programs, and laboratory closures."

The halt applies only to the 22 states — including Arizona, Michigan, New York, Hawaii and Massachusetts — that sued. No states with Republican governors joined. Kelley's ruling is not final but applies as the case continues in court.

UC President Michael Drake said in a statement Monday that the cuts, if real- [See [NIH](#), A7]



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